Pumpkin-Pot Chicken

Ingredients

Cooking pumpkin . . . . . 1 (8–12 lb.)
Chicken leg quarters, skin-on 4 (3–3½ lb.)
Kosher salt . . . . . 1 Tbsp. plus more
Black pepper . . . . . 1 tsp.
Vegetable oil . . . . . 1 Tbsp.
Yellow onion, large 1
Leek, large 1
Shallots 2
Garlic cloves 6
Dried thyme . . . . . 1 tsp.
Rubbed sage . . . . . ¾ tsp.
Bay leaves 2
Dry white wine . . . . . ½ cup
Chicken stock . . . . . 1 cup
Ears of corn 2
Apple cider vinegar . . . . . 2 Tbsp.
Unsalted butter . . . . . 1 Tbsp.

Directions

Heat the oven to *325°F* — Wash the **pumpkin**. Cut a lid large enough for the **chicken**, with the knife angled so the lid sits down into the opening. Scrape out the seeds and strings. Salt the inside lightly — Dice the **onion**. Halve the **leek** lengthwise, rinse out the grit, and slice the white and pale green. Slice the **shallots**. Mince the **garlic** — Cut the kernels from the **corn**. Break the cobs in half — Pat the **chicken** dry. Season it all over with 1 Tbsp. **kosher salt** and ½ tsp. **black pepper**

1. Set a large cast-iron skillet or other all-metal pan over medium-high heat. Add 1 Tbsp. **vegetable oil**. Brown the **chicken** in two batches, skin-side down, without moving it, for *8–10 minutes*, until the skin is deep golden and releases from the pan. Turn and cook *2–3 minutes* more, until the other side has color. Move the **chicken** to a plate. Leave about 2 Tbsp. of fat in the pan.

2. Lower the heat to medium. Add the **onion**, **leek**, and **shallots** with a pinch of **kosher salt**. Cook, stirring now and then, until they soften and the pan goes from wet to pale gold, *10–12 minutes*. Stir in the **garlic**, 1 tsp. **dried thyme**, and ¾ tsp. **rubbed sage**. Cook for *1 minute*, until the garlic smells sweet and stays pale.

3. Add ½ cup **dry white wine**. Scrape the fond off the pan. Cook until only a glaze is left on the vegetables, *2–4 minutes*. Add 1 cup **chicken stock** and the **bay leaves**. Bring it to a simmer.

4. Set the **chicken** skin-side up in the **pumpkin**. Tuck the **corn** cobs around it where they fit. Pour the pan contents around the **chicken**. Set the lid on. Cover the stem with foil. Put the **pumpkin** in the pan and bake at *325°F* for *1½ hours*.

5. Lift the lid. Take out the cobs and the **bay leaves**. Add the **corn** kernels. Cover again and bake *30 minutes* more. It is done when the thickest part of a thigh reads *185°F*, the meat has pulled back at the joint, and a knife slides into the **pumpkin** wall with little resistance. Continue in *15 minute* stretches until it does. The skin will be soft.

6. Rest, covered, for *15 minutes*. Move the **chicken** to a platter. Skim the fat from the broth. Stir in 1 Tbsp. **unsalted butter**. Add 1 Tbsp. **apple cider vinegar**, then more, up to the remaining tablespoon, until the broth tastes savory and bright. Season with the remaining **black pepper** and more **kosher salt**. Serve each bowl with **pumpkin** flesh scraped off the skin, **chicken**, **corn**, and broth. It is best in the first *20 minutes*.

Equipment Required

- Cast-iron skillet or other all-metal pan wide enough to hold the pumpkin and fit in the oven
- Large plate
- Tongs
- Wooden spoon
- Knife and cutting board
- Measuring cups and spoons
- Aluminum foil
- Instant-read thermometer
- Ladle

Hints and Notes

Yield

- Serves 4.
- One quarter is a serving. The pumpkin and the broth fill the bowls.

Mise en Place

- Heat the oven to *325°F* before you brown the **chicken**.
- Cut and scrape the **pumpkin** first. The lid has to fit back on.
- Cut the **onion**, **leek**, **shallots**, and **garlic**. Keep them on the board.
- Cut the **corn** kernels free. Break the cobs in half.
- Pat the **chicken** dry and season it.
- Measure the **wine**, **stock**, **thyme**, **sage**, **vinegar**, and **butter** before the pan is hot.

Ingredient Tips

- Use a cooking pumpkin, such as Cinderella or Long Island Cheese. A carving pumpkin is watery. A sugar pie pumpkin is too small for four quarters.
- The pumpkin and the pan have to fit in the oven together.
- Eight skin-on **drumsticks** can stand in for the quarters. Use the same heat and the same tests for doneness.
- **Kosher salt** here is Diamond Crystal. Morton is denser. Use 2 tsp. Morton on the **chicken** in place of 1 Tbsp. Diamond Crystal.
- Use rubbed **sage**. Ground sage is stronger. Use 1/2 tsp. ground sage in its place.
- **Dry white wine**: Sauvignon Blanc or Pinot Grigio. Skip anything sweet.
- A fresh pumpkin gives off a lot of liquid. The 1 cup of **stock** is enough.

Preparation Tips

- Angle the lid cut so the top sits in the hole and the steam stays inside.
- Foil on the stem keeps it from scorching.
- Brown in two batches. A crowded pan steams the skin and leaves a pale fond.
- The **pumpkin** wall cooks more slowly than the meat. Dark meat can stay in until the wall yields to a knife.
- Take the cobs out when the kernels go in. They have already flavored the broth.
- A thin broth can go back into the pan and simmer *5–8 minutes* before you add the **vinegar** and **butter**.

Make Ahead & Storage

- Cook it the day you serve it. The **pumpkin** is at its best the first night.

- Refrigerate leftover **chicken**, **pumpkin** flesh, and broth up to *3 days*.
- Reheat, covered, over low heat until the **chicken** is hot.
- Blend leftover **pumpkin** flesh with leftover broth for soup. Warm it gently and taste for salt and **vinegar**.

Serving Suggestions

- Bring the **pumpkin** to the table in the pan. Ladle the broth, then lift out the **chicken**.
- Crusty bread is the right thing for the broth.
- It stays hot in the **pumpkin** after the first *20 minutes*. The skin stays soft.